alone. It is a new way of growing. From the rest of the state overall, we get about 400 a month. This totals up to about 8,000–10,000 a month on average new registrations in Karnataka. They are mostly young students and young people.'[24]

By early 2020, the RSS had about 4,000 shakhas in Karnataka: 62.5 per cent of these were in north Karnataka (2,500); 37.5 per cent in south Karnataka (1,500). Holla, who is an IT engineer working for the RSS in his spare time, explained that traditionally Bengaluru had been the biggest growth area for RSS shakhas, along with the districts of Shivamogga and Mangalore (in Dakshin Kannada). In recent years though, there had been a major expansion in the south Karnataka districts of Tumkur, Kolar, Mysore and Mandya—'very good growth', as he put it.[25]

Coastal Karnataka and the areas around Mangalore were where the RSS set up its first shakhas in Karnataka in the 1940s and 1950s. It was an early start, but a major factor that held back further expansion until the 1990s was the language barrier (see Chapter 15 for more on this).[26] The early RSS pracharaks were all from Maharashtra and spoke Marathi, not Kannada. Their message was received and found an audience in Karnataka's coastal areas, where most people speak Konkani, or in Bangalore, where a large mass of north Indian migrants spoke Hindi. Vadhiraj, an RSS worker who has worked for over two decades with SC/ST groups and headed communications for the Karnataka South zone for ten years, explained that 'language was not an issue in the [Bengaluru] city here' and in the 'coastal areas, the language was Konkani, so they could talk'.[27]

Local RSS leaders in Karnataka attributed the Sangh's recent growth to the use of social media and its recourse to communication in the local languages. 'Now in Karnataka,' said Vadhiraj, 'all pracharaks are from Karnataka, so they can expand and reach out. All our activities happen now in Kannada.'[28] Holla said, 'I should credit this growth to social media also. So, areas where we had less presence earlier, like Tumkur, are now growing.' Sangh leaders say that, typically, it is easier to organise weekly gatherings in new areas.